

UNDERCOVER

The Perfect Match

Agent 001 is seeking the cheapest motherboard-processor combination that's setting off the most sparks



Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

Pair a Cyrix III 550 costing less than Rs 2,000 with a 810e motherboard, and you have a combination for less than Rs 5,000. Beat that!

Some things go hand in hand—strawberries and cream, icing and cake and, of course, motherboards and processors! Not that I have a one-track mind, but my latest mission had me looking for a motherboard-processor combination that was easy on my pockets and packed a punch as well.

So I headed into the market looking for some really cheap but not necessarily low performing hardware.

First stop Lamington Road, Mumbai. Vendor One seems to be a big AMD fan and promises P-III like performance from the Duron. While the Duron can definitely give the Pentium III a run for its money, its biggest problem is an unavailability of cheap motherboards to complement it. This vendor could only offer platforms such as the ASUS A7V and other expensive brands. These motherboards are great performers but aren't as easy on the pocket.

So I hop over to the next shop in line where Vendor Two tells me that the Celeron II is doing well and has a plethora of choices as far as cheap motherboards are concerned. So I decided to put a cap on my budget now and asked to be shown a motherboard processor combo within Rs 8,000.

Then the vendor advised me to go in for the Celeron II 700, costing about Rs 3,000. "Add to it an 810e board for Rs 3,500 or less and you are all set," he said.

One board that was mentioned time and again was the Tiga 810+. Great! But I said I wanted some AGP functionality. Vendor Three aptly recommended an 815e. The cheapest he

could think of were the Jetway and Mercury boards (Jetway J618AF and Mercury KOB-815E FSX). So I now had a deal worth Rs 8,000 but I decided to push on a bit further. I asked for a really cheap combination and even said that I was

ready to sacrifice a bit of gaming. Vendor Two hit the nail straight on the head, recommending a Cyrix III 550 at less than Rs 2,000.

To top it, these processors run on all socket 370 boards, so pair it with an 810e and you get one cheap combination. A complete motherboard and CPU combination for less than Rs 5,000. Beat that!

Next I headed up north looking for a combination that could really give these so-called 'high-end' players a run for their money. The first vendor suggested the typical SiS 630 chipset based solutions, which are a great value as far as cheap solutions for the Celeron and Celeron II are concerned.

Sadly, no other vendor recommended a cheap Duron solution although both DFI and Azza have decent AMD solutions. Some vendors even tried to push some really old and cheap 440BX and VIA 693 based boards. I would seriously not go in for these motherboards unless I have some cheap Celerons lying around.

Going further north (Powai), I walked into a swanky shop in Hiranandani and met with a pretty knowledgeable chap. I pushed for a Duron solution and was very rightly suggested the Azza KT-133TX board. He then went on to recommend a Duron 800: "The combo will cost you only Rs 9,000, not a rupee more."

Remember, that some of the KT-133 based platforms for the AMD processors don't come with onboard VGA. Only solutions based on the KM133 such as the DFI AM35 EC come with onboard VGA and with pretty decent performance too (incorporating a Savage 4 based solution). Pairing the Duron 800 with the DFI AM35 EC would be just nudging Rs 9,000.

Closer to home, I enter a local shop at Andheri (W), displaying P-IV advertisements. I learnt that a P-IV kit sets you back by Rs 30,000 plus a very expensive cabinet (no less than Rs 4,000). Yes, the performance is great. But if all you want is to get online for some office work then the cheaper combinations are the ones to look at. Remember, cheap doesn't necessarily mean bad or under-performing. All it means is that you will get only what you pay for and maybe hope for more! ■

Want to share your experiences with getting a motherboard and processor
Write in to readersletters@jasubhai.com

Go for Value

AMD-based systems

Duron 700-900 MHz+
DFIAM35EC motherboard

Intel and Cyrix-based systems

Celeron or Cyrix III+
Tiga 810+ motherboard